

StoryDogs Teaching Guide

Step 1: HERO - Who's Your Hero?

Keep these pages beside you during a classroom, library, or author-led activity. Each page explains one step, offers wording you can say aloud, and helps you build on students' answers without choosing their story for them.

Project the questions and invite students to contribute one stage at a time. Open 'Show our answers' to revisit the group's ideas, then print the outline. Younger writers can use it as a short story; older writers can add scenes and details between its main events.

What this step does

Give readers someone to care about. Your hero is the main character, even if they do not have superpowers or feel brave yet.

The two student questions

1. Who is your main character? Give them a name and tell us a little about them.
2. What is something they struggle with or are afraid of?

You might say

We are choosing someone to follow through the story. They need something interesting about them and something that is hard for them. That difficulty gives us room to see them grow. A hero can start out worried, quiet, or unsure.

Listen for and help them go further

A specific character and a difficulty that could shape an action. If a student says 'nice' or 'scared,' ask what the character does that lets us see it. Help students invent fictional difficulties; they do not need to share personal worries.

Questions to keep the conversation moving

- What would we notice if we spent five minutes with your hero?
- What can they do well, and what feels difficult?
- When that difficult thing happens, what do they do?

Follow Pip's connected example

Pip is a tiny dragon who breathes flowers instead of fire. Pip loves growing things but is afraid to ask for help, so Pip hides mistakes and tries to fix everything alone.

Use these questions as conversation starters. For younger writers, invite a spoken answer or a drawing first; an adult can help record their words. Keep the student's choices at the heart of the story.

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Step 2: WISH - A Wish and an Ordinary Day

What this step does

Show the starting point and give your hero a reason to act. A wish gives the story a direction; knowing why it matters helps readers care.

The two student questions

1. What is your character's life like before the adventure begins?
2. What does your character want, and why does it matter to them?

You might say

Let's take a picture of life before the adventure. Now let's give our hero a wish. 'They want a prize' tells us what they want. 'They want a prize because they hope their family will notice their hard work' tells us why we should care.

Listen for and help them go further

Both an ordinary life and a want with a personal reason. If the wish is vague, ask how we would know it had come true. Keep the hero's earlier difficulty in mind; wanting a friend while being afraid to ask for help gives later choices meaning.

Questions to keep the conversation moving

- What does your hero do on a normal day?
- What do they hope will happen or change?
- If they got their wish, what would it mean to them?

Follow Pip's connected example

Pip usually tends a little flower patch alone after school. Pip wants to help at the school garden fair and make a friend, because growing beautiful things feels better when someone shares the fun.

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Step 3: UH-OH! - Uh-Oh... Everything Changes!

What this step does

Interrupt the ordinary day. This is the change that starts the adventure, followed by the hero's decision to do something about it.

The two student questions

1. What happens that changes your character's normal life?
2. What does your character decide to do because of it?

You might say

Up to now, we have shown ordinary life and a wish. Here we tip the first domino: something changes. Our hero does not have to choose perfectly, but they do need to choose an action. What will they do because of this new situation?

Listen for and help them go further

A clear change and an action that follows from it. If the answer introduces an unrelated surprise, ask how it affects the wish. If another character makes every decision, ask what choice belongs to the hero.

Questions to keep the conversation moving

- What happens that makes today different?
- Why does that change matter to this hero?
- What do they decide to do first?

Follow Pip's connected example

On the morning of the garden fair, Pip discovers that the display flowers have wilted. Pip decides to grow replacements with flower breath, hoping to help the fair and meet the other young gardeners.

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Step 4: TROUBLE - Here Comes Trouble!

What this step does

Put something in the way of the hero's goal. Their attempt to solve it creates the next part of the story.

The two student questions

1. What problem gets in the way when your character tries to reach their goal?
2. What do they try, and how does that create the next problem?

You might say

Trouble gives our hero something to work on. We want a chain of events: this happens, so they try that, and their attempt leads to something new. A problem does not need a villain. A tangled gate or a misunderstanding can be plenty of trouble.

Listen for and help them go further

An obstacle, an attempt, and a result connected by 'because' or 'so.' If a student lists random problems, ask which one comes from the hero's last action. If everything is solved already, ask what remains difficult or what the attempt has changed.

Questions to keep the conversation moving

- What stops the hero's first plan from working?
- What do they try to get past that problem?
- Because they try that, what new problem appears?

Follow Pip's connected example

Pip's new flowers grow tangled vines across the garden gate. Pip tries to pull them loose alone, but the vines drag pots into the path. Now visitors cannot get in, and the entrance is a mess.

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Step 5: YIKES! - Trouble Gets an Upgrade!

What this step does

Make the problem harder and show what matters. Readers should understand what the hero might miss or lose if the plan fails.

The two student questions

1. How does the situation become even more difficult?
2. What could your character lose if they fail now?

You might say

Here we turn up the pressure on the same problem. We do not need danger or fighting. A deadline, a broken promise, or a friend feeling ignored can make the moment important. What might our hero lose, and why would that hurt this particular hero?

Listen for and help them go further

A stronger version of the existing problem and a consequence connected to the hero's wish. If the answer is 'everything,' ask for one specific thing. Keep the pressure suitable for the story; a small problem can still feel very big to its character.

Questions to keep the conversation moving

- What makes the existing problem harder now?
- What matters to the hero that could be lost?
- How does this make their earlier fear or difficulty harder to face?

Follow Pip's connected example

The fair is about to open, and the gate is still blocked. Another young gardener wants to help, but Pip keeps refusing. Pip could spoil the fair and lose the chance to make a friend-the very things Pip hoped for.

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Step 6: SHOWDOWN - Time for the Big Moment!

What this step does

Bring the main problem to its biggest moment. Give the hero a choice that helps decide how it turns out.

The two student questions

1. What is the biggest challenge your character must face?
2. What do they choose to do, and what happens because of that choice?

You might say

This is the moment the earlier steps have been building toward. It does not have to be a fight. The brave choice might be telling the truth or asking for help. Let's make the hero's decision matter, using something we have already learned about them.

Listen for and help them go further

A challenge, a meaningful choice, and its result. If a new power or a stranger suddenly fixes everything, ask what the hero could contribute using an earlier skill or clue. The hero does not have to win everything; a thoughtful choice can lead to a different kind of success.

Questions to keep the conversation moving

- What must your hero face or try right now?
- What difficult choice do they make?
- How does that choice change the main problem?

Follow Pip's connected example

Pip admits that the gate is too tangled to fix alone and asks the other gardener for help. Together, they use Pip's flower-growing skill and the gardener's tools to turn the vines into a welcoming arch. Pip chooses teamwork, and the gate opens in time.

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Step 7: AFTER! - What's Different Now?

What this step does

Show what the adventure has changed. Help readers see how the hero or their everyday life is different from the beginning.

The two student questions

1. What has your character learned, or how have they changed?
2. What is their life like at the end of the story?

You might say

An ending does more than stop the action. It lets us notice what the journey has changed. Instead of only saying 'they learned kindness,' show us a kind action. Compare the beginning and the end: what would our hero do differently on an ordinary day now?

Listen for and help them go further

A change supported by something that happened in the story, plus a glimpse of life afterward. If the answer is only 'happy,' ask what the hero does or understands now. An ending can be funny, quiet, hopeful, or bittersweet; it does not need a perfect life or a stated moral.

Questions to keep the conversation moving

- What did the hero learn through their choices?
- What can they do now that was hard at the beginning?
- What everyday moment would show us the change?

Follow Pip's connected example

Pip learns that asking for help can bring people closer. The next day, Pip invites the other gardener to tend the flower patch together. Pip still breathes flowers instead of fire, but now feels proud of that gift and shares it with a friend.

Use these questions as conversation starters. For younger writers, invite a spoken answer or a drawing first; an adult can help record their words. Keep the student's choices at the heart of the story.